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INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 12~06~2026

-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

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Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

NITI AAYOG GOVERNING COUNCIL MEETING

PM calls for district GDP estimates, CMs press for affordable energy

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, June 11

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi Thursday asked states to pursue investments from partner countries by addressing grievances rapidly and to come up with district-level GDP estimates to deal with growth-related challenges at the grassroots level.

He was addressing the 11th Governing Council meeting of Niti Aayog which was attended

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(From right) Chief Ministers DK Shivakumar, Hemant Soren, Nayab Singh Saini, and Rekha Gupta at NITI Aayog meeting, Thursday. ANI

Kerala’s 1st Nipah case this yr: Trader whose godown had fruit bats hospitalised

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, June 11

A 43-YEAR-OLD man in Kozhikode on Thursday tested positive for Nipah virus, making the first such case in Kerala in 2026. After National Institute of Virology-Pune confirmed the infection, the health department sounded an alert in Kozhikode, which had a recurring history of Nipah cases including the deadly outbreak of 2018. Official sources said the confirmed case is admitted to the ICU of the government medical college hospital in Kozhikode, while 77 persons in his contact list have been identified. As many as 13 of them in the high risk category have been quarantined. Kozhikode district collector MS Madhavikutty said a control room has been opened and a route map of the infected person has been prepared for initiating field-level preventive steps. Of the 77 persons in the contact list, 58 are health workers, 14 are his relatives/family members and five are his friends. A rapid response team has been activated in Ramanattukaramunicipality, where the infected person resided. The patient is a trader whose godown is situated close to thick vegetation. According to Health officials, when the trader opened the godown after a long time, he saw a large number of fruit bats, which are considered the reservoir of the virus. Before being admitted to the

medical college hospital on Tuesday, the patient had sought treatment at another hospital in his locality. The severe zoonotic disease was first detected in Kerala in 2018, in Kozhikode district. Out of 18 cases that year, 17 died. In 2021, the state saw another outbreak, killing one person. In 2023, two Nipah deaths were reported in Kerala, and in 2024, there were two deaths. Last year, Kerala reported four cases of Nipah, out of which two patients died. The total death toll from the Nipah virus in Kerala since 2018 is 24. All the outbreaks in Kerala were reported in the May to September period, which encompasses the main rainy season in the state. With other viral fevers and the flu also a common occurrence in this season, the early diagnosis of Nipah, which has similar initial symptoms, has been a challenge. A study on the 2018 outbreak found that the index case was infected from bats, and the others from the hospital where the patient was admitted. The virus reported in Kerala belonged to a Bangladeshi strain, which is known for a mortality rate of up to 90%. A field survey conducted by NIV and National Institute of High Security Animal Diseases after the Nipah death in July 2024 indicated fruit bats as the source of infection. The presence of antibodies to the virus was detected in fruit bats’ samples collected from the village where the July victim lived.

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Niti

by all CMs including those appointed recently — Tamil Nadu’s C. Joseph Vijay, West Bengal’s Suvendu Adhikari, Karnataka’s D. K. Shivakumar, and Kerala’s V. D. Satheesan. Niti Aayog members said the CMs sought more support for elderly care and professional skilling. “This was the first time when Chief Ministers of all 28 states participated in the Governing Council Meeting of NITI Aayog,” an official statement said. Members who attended the meeting said energy and a redoubled manufacturing push were the focal points of the meeting, and several CMs raised the need for energy availability at competitive prices and support in spreading solar infrastructure so that dependency of households on the grid is reduced. The issue of affordable energy comes amid rising fuel prices in the backdrop of the West Asia crisis.

NITI Aayog Vice Chairperson Ashok Kumar Lahiri said, “On energy, there was a lot of discussion... on making energy prices competitive and making reliable energy available. The governing council members also talked about spreading solar energy on rooftops, in residential buildings, in schools, hospitals and government buildings so that dependence of households on grid electricity is reduced and the subsidy problem becomes manageable.” The PM, according to the official statement, emphasised on women-led development. He asked the states to work on increasing the number of Lakhpati Didis from 3 crore to 6 crore and stressed the importance of ensuring a safe and secure environment for Nari Shakti. “The Prime Minister urged states to focus on One District One Product (ODOP) initiatives and develop export-oriented strategies around it. He also identified defence manufactur-

ing as an emerging sector where India is establishing a distinct identity, and encouraged states to formulate policies to leverage the opportunities arising from its growth,” the statement said. Telangana CM Revanth Reddy, in a social media post, said he requested the PM’s intervention in expediting approvals and support for crucial projects such as Hyderabad Metro Rail expansion, Regional Ring Road, 12-lane expressway from Future City to Bandar seaport in Andhra Pradesh, airports at Warangal and Adilabad, among others. J&K CM Omar Abdullah said on X he discussed key issues concerning J&K, including the early restoration of statehood, the state of economy and pace of development. To prepare Jharkhand’s youth for jobs in AI, green energy and other tech industries, CM Hemant Soren sought Central help for an estimated Rs 800-crore project to establish a Skill University and a FinTech University in the state.



Jal Ganga Samvardhan Abhiyan

Madhya Pradesh Prepares to Save Every Drop



NARENDRA MODI
Prime Minister

A Participatory Model of Water Governance



CM Dr.Mohan Yadav addressing Ganga Dussehra Celebration at Ujjain as a part of Jal Ganga Samvardhan Abhiyan.

Madhya Pradesh has successfully taken up revival of water bodies seeking larger public participation under Jal Ganga Samvardhan Abhiyan.

Chief Minister Dr. Mohan Yadav's Water Conservation Vision

Chief Minister Dr. Mohan Yadav has been consistently urging citizens to act in unison for conservation of water. He emphasizes that every member of society must develop a sense of responsibility towards water conservation. In his numerous public speeches, the philosophy of water has been spelled out meticulously. The key messages include -

- Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi is the driving force behind the national people's movement for water conservation.
- Water is a key parameter of development. If there is water, there is a prosperous future.
- Under the Prime Minister's leadership, historic initiatives such as the Ministry of Jal Shakti, Jal Jeevan Mission, Namami Gange, Amrit Sarovar Mission, and Jal Shakti Ab-

hiyan have been launched.

- Rivers are revered and worshipped as goddesses in Indian culture.
- Efforts have been made in every district for the construction or restoration of 75 water bodies. More than 70,000 Amrit Sarovars have been developed so far, enhancing rainwater harvesting, groundwater recharge, and irrigation facilities. This mission is part of the Azadi Ka Amrit Mahotsav celebrations. Work is also underway under the Namami Gange project, including sewage treatment plants, riverfront development, and biodiversity conservation.
- The Prime Minister Krishi Sinchayee Yojana promotes the principle of "More Crop per Drop."
- The Catch the Rain campaign has transformed rainwater harvesting into a mass movement. Under the Prime Minister's guidance, lakhs of water conservation structures have been created, including check dams, rainwater harvesting systems, and the restoration of traditional water sources.
- As a result, groundwater recharge has

increased, the number of over-exploited groundwater units has declined, and water scarcity has reduced in several districts.

- Madhya Pradesh is also undertaking exemplary initiatives in the field of water conservation.
- The Jal Ganga Samvardhan Abhiyan is a statewide public movement. In 2025, the campaign was conducted from March 19 to June 30. In 2026 as well, it has been implemented with full vigor across the state. Maintenance work has been carried out on more than 10,000 check dams and stop dams.
- Thousands of ponds have been deepened, and new water conservation structures have been constructed.
- Water conservation works worth approximately Rs. 2,500 crore have been undertaken.
- Ancient step wells, ponds, and water structures are valuable cultural heritage assets. Their restoration enhances cultural pride and promotes tourism.
- Madhya Pradesh is emerging as a leading state in water conservation in India.

Urban MP engaged in Water Conservation

Extensive work has been undertaken for water conservation in urban areas. The Urban Development and Housing Department has carried out large-scale initiatives such as restoration and rejuvenation of ponds, wells, and ancient stepwells, cleaning and beautification of drains, and the installation of rainwater harvesting systems. Urban local bodies set up drinking water kiosks at various locations for convenience of local citizens.

CM calls for Shramdan

PUBLIC AWARENESS BUILDING

On the call of Chief Minister Dr. Mohan Yadav, extensive public awareness programs on water conservation across the state have been taken up. More than 5.25 lakh people actively participated in these initiatives. In addition, 2,682 Water Temples have been set up in various development blocks.



Chief Minister Dr. Yadav Performs Shramdan at Devi Sagar Talab on Ganga Dussehra.

Shipra Tirth Parikrama



Under the leadership of Chief Minister Dr. Mohan Yadav, the State Government has been continuously working towards achieving self-reliance in water. The Jal Ganga Samvardhan Abhiyan, launched to conserve and rejuvenate rivers, ponds, and traditional water structures, has now evolved into a mass movement with widespread public participation.

As part of the campaign, the "Shipra Tirth Parikrama" in Ujjain was organized. During the event, Chief Minister Dr. Yadav offered a 351-foot-long chunari to the sacred Maa Shipra River. The campaign is also accelerating conservation efforts through the cleaning and restoration of Futera Talab and ancient stepwells across the state. The campaign is spreading the message: "Conservation of Every Drop, Save Life."



CM Dr. Yadav Offering 351-Foot Chunari to Maa Shipra during 'Shipra Tirth Parikrama' in Ujjain

Revival of Holy Ghats of Shipra

Celebrating Ganga Dussehra with huge mass gathering in Ujjain underlined that people have willingly contributing to saving water. Addressing the valedictory ceremony of the Shipra Tirth Parikrama, CM Dr. Yadav stated that during Simhastha-2028, the ghats of Maa Shipra, developed over a stretch of more than 30 kilometres, will enable devotees to take the holy dip and earn spiritual merit. The ghats of Maa-Shipra, stretching from Triveni to Siddhnath, are considered sacred. Availability of clean and continuously flowing waters of Maa Shipra will enhance the sanctity of the event. After nearly six decades, devotees attending Simhastha will once again be able to bathe in the naturally flowing waters of Maa Shipra. The government is ensuring excellent arrangements to make Simhastha-2028 memorable and set new benchmarks.

Cleaning of Water Sources Becomes A Mass Movement

Madhya Pradesh has successfully taken up water conservation initiatives under the Jal Ganga Samvardhan Abhiyan. This has now become a mass movement and has achieved historic milestones in water conservation. The campaign is being conducted across the state from 19 March to 30 June 2026.

Various activities are being organized across the districts under the Jal Ganga Samvardhan Abhiyan for the conservation and enhancement of water resources. The campaign aims to promote rainwater harvesting, preserve traditional water sources, and raise community awareness about water conservation.

As part of the campaign, the cleaning of wells, stepwells, ponds, reservoirs, and drains is being carried out on a war footing in villages and urban areas across the districts. Efforts are being made to revive these water sources through the active participation of Gram Panchayats, schools, Anganwadi centers, voluntary organizations, and local citizens.

Residents were also educated about household water conservation measures, including rainwater harvesting and ways to prevent water wastage. The campaign has witnessed active involvement from the District Administration, Janpad Panchayats, Urban Local Bodies, the



Water Resources Department, and other related departments. Local public representatives, social workers, and youth have also enthusiastically participated in these activities.

All citizens were counselled to protect water sources, use water judiciously, and adopt rainwater harvesting practices to help prevent future water crises. The campaign is emerging as a strong initiative towards achieving water self-reliance in the districts through active public participation.

Madhya Pradesh Earns National Recognition in Water Conservation

Over 2.17 Lacs Works Completed



Madhya Pradesh has made a significant progress in water conservation across the country. Many districts have achieved top rankings. Khandwa got first position.

PERFORMANCE RANKING 2026

Ranking	District	Score
1	Khandwa	7.75
2	Ujjain	7.49
3	Khargone	7.10
4	Balaghat	7.04
5	Neemuch	7.00

Integrated Dashboard

To ensure regular monitoring of the campaign on a single platform, an Integrated Dashboard has been developed. Through this system, all departments are recording and tracking their respective activities. The dashboard also facilitates district-wise rankings, promoting administrative and departmental transparency as well as healthy competition among districts.

PROGRESS CHART From 2024 to 2026

Year	Activities Done
2024	62,000 Work Done
	40,108 New Ventures
	21,536 Water Bodies Revived
2025	86,360 Water Bodies Recovered
	553 Amrit Sarovar Works completed
2026	2,17,843 Work Completed
	61,030 Farm Pond
	157 Amrit Sarovar
	94,073 Dug Well Recharge
	1206 Irrigation Infrastructure
	31,656 Water Conservation & Recharge
	5,116 Watershed Related Works
	2,883 Repair & Maintenance (Water Structure)
	12.76 Cr.Gap Filling in Plantation
	11,550 Work Not Permissible in VB-GRAM-G
	169.47 PMKSY Watershed
	2,288,403 JSJB 2.0
	6,887 Water Tank Cleaning in Schools(WoW app)

MP's Victory of Participatory Approach

Positive outcome reported from across districts

Water management has brought significant improvements in agriculture, the environment, and livelihoods. The Jal Ganga Samvardhan Abhiyan has emerged as an effective medium for water conservation, environmental protection, and rural development across Madhya Pradesh. The campaign has accelerated the restoration of water sources and the construction of new water conservation structures. Public participation has strengthened water management efforts.

As a result, water availability has increased in various districts of the state, agricultural productivity has improved, biodiversity has been conserved, rural economies have become stronger, and people's livelihoods have witnessed positive changes.

Chhindwara: Pond Construction in Palachaurai Boosts Agricultural Productivity

Palachaurai village in Junnardeo block of Chhindwara district has emerged as a model of greenery and prosperity. Under the campaign, priority was given to the construction of water structures and the revival of old water sources.

Through coordinated efforts of the Fisheries Department and the Panchayat & Rural Development Department, ponds ranging from half an acre to two-and-a-half acres were constructed, ensuring year-round water availability.

The rise in groundwater levels has directly benefited agriculture. Farmers who were previously dependent on rainfall are now practicing irrigated farming. Currently, they are harvesting up to three crops annually, leading to increased production and income.

Production of wheat, gram, lentils, mustard, and peas during the Rabi season has increased significantly. Farmers are also able to cultivate green gram (moong) and black gram (urad) during the summer season. In addition, they have developed alternative sources of income through fish farming,



pearl cultivation, and water chestnut production.

As a result, the village's economic condition has improved, migration has declined, and young people are becoming self-reliant by engaging in agriculture.

Gwalior: Revival of Prithvi Tal

In Gwalior district, the historic Prithvi Tal has been rejuvenated under the Jal Ganga Samvardhan Abhiyan. It has been transformed into a modern, functional, and attractive water reservoir.

Spread across approximately 7.27 hectares, the pond had previously been severely affected by siltation, water hyacinth growth, and encroachments, making it nearly unusable. It has been revived as an effective center for water conservation.

Extensive desilting, deepening, and cleaning activities were carried out under the campaign, increasing the pond's



water storage capacity. The fertile soil removed from the pond was used in nearby agricultural fields, providing additional benefits to farmers.

Following beautification efforts, the site has become a popular picnic destination and a center for recreational and health-related activities. One of the most significant achievements has been the restoration of biodiversity.

Currently, more than 120 species of native and migratory birds inhabit the area. Turtles and other aquatic creatures have also returned, transforming the site into a vibrant ecosystem.

Mandsaur: Restoration of Thadod's Historic Stepwell Provides a Sustainable Water Source

In Thadod village of Mandsaur district, the revival of the historic Hazrat Ghalib Baori (stepwell) has emerged as an inspiring achievement.

For years, the stepwell had remained neglected and unusable due to accumulated debris, dirt, and poor maintenance. Under the campaign, the administration and local villagers actively participated in its restoration.

Through voluntary labor, debris was removed, the water source was cleaned, and the surrounding area was developed and organized. As a result, the stepwell has once again become a clean, safe, and functional water source.

The campaign has not only preserved an important historical heritage site but has also provided villagers with a sustainable source of water. It is expected to contribute to groundwater recharge and has become a source of inspiration for other villages.

Towards Sustainable Development

The efforts being undertaken under the Jal Ganga Samvardhan Abhiyan are bringing meaningful changes in the conservation and utilization of water resources across Madhya Pradesh.

The examples of Chhindwara, Gwalior, and Mandsaur demonstrate that well-planned implementation combined with active community participation can deliver sustainable results at the local level.

This initiative is not only addressing current water needs but is also laying a strong foundation for future water security, thereby promoting balanced and long-term development throughout the state.

MOTOR ACCIDENT CLAIMS

‘Homemakers nation builders’: SC puts ‘loss of domestic care’ at Rs 30K monthly

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, June 11

DEFINING HOMEMAKERS as “nation builders”, the Supreme Court on Thursday fixed Rs 30,000 as their notional monthly income for the purpose of motor accident claims in the event of their death.

In a judgment which is likely to have wide implications on cases related to the Motor Vehicles Act, the bench of Justices Sanjoy Karol and N Kotiswar Singh held that “a composite sum of Rs 30,000 shall be added under the head of loss of domestic care” in motor accident claims linked to the death of a homemaker. The bench passed the order while granting additional compensation in a road accident dating back to November 25, 2001, when a woman died while she was on her way from Sirsa to Fatehabad (Haryana).

Her husband and three children approached the Motor Accident Claims Tribunal, which granted compensation of Rs 2.42 lakh in December 2023. They then went to the Punjab and Haryana High Court, which, in December 2024, enhanced the compensation to Rs 8.43 lakh along with 7.5% interest from the date of filing the claim petition. The family then approached the Supreme Court. The top court Thursday increased the compensation to Rs 62.78 lakh, noting the contribution of a homemaker to the “growth of the human being and the nation”, and quantifying the “loss of domestic care monthly income” at Rs 30,000.

“When a Motor Accidents Claim Tribunal or the High Court or this Court is concerned with a case involving the death of a homemaker, in order to overcome the inherent disadvantage accrued against the homemaker on a calculation of compensation on the basis of conservatively computed notional income... a composite sum of Rs 30,000 shall be added under the head of ‘loss of domestic care’,” the bench said. “This amount of Rs 30,000, i.e., loss of domestic care, is to be taken as a ‘stand-in’ (basic mini-

mum monthly income) for monthly income in those cases where the homemaker does not have an input into the house, in strictly conventional, monetary terms. In those cases where the homemaker is part of the workforce, the component of loss of domestic care shall be in addition to the monthly income as may be proved before the tribunal/ courts... It is our hope that the word housewife/ homemaker, is in future, in recognition of the contributions of the lady of the house... is now used as ‘nation builder’.”

Writing for the bench, Justice Karol said: “The loss of a homemaker, however, is not limited to the husband and children. It also directly impacts the women’s parents who have been deprived of the love and company of their child... Still further, the loss is acutely felt by her in-laws, who are more often than not members of the same household and are therefore dependent on the love, labour and dedication of this person... Strict arithmetic calculation does not lend its service to any of these scenarios.”

The court said that in its view, “it is ironic to describe a homemaker as dependant on earning members, when, in reality the household’s functioning depends substantially on the homemaker. The earning members are, in fact, solely dependent on the homemaker but alas, this reality does not receive the acknowledgment it deserves. Efforts have been made across fields to some success, but yet, undeniably, the road is long.”

The bench also expressed concern over the delay in deciding motor accident claims, and issued a series of directions in this regard. It said that an analysis of the 100 appeals decided by the SC “reveals that the average pendency in the High Courts is approximately eight years and before the (Motor Accident Claims) Tribunals... is approximately six years”. The SC asked Chief Justices of High Courts to take steps to decide pending cases without further delay.

FULL REPORT ON
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‘Patriarchal preference for male child’: SC says strict enforcement of PCPNDT Act needed

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 11

THE SUPREME Court on Friday said “deep-seated patriarchal preferences towards a male child and the behind the curtains prevalence of sex-selection practices” continue to exist in the country despite improvement in the national child sex ratio.

A bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and P K Mishra made the observation as it dismissed a Maharashtra doctor’s appeal challenging criminal proceedings against him under the Pre-Conception and Pre-Natal Diagnostic Techniques (Prohibition of Sex Selection) Act, 1994 (PCPNDT Act).

Citing various schemes started by state governments to curb female foeticide and improve the condition of women, the SC said they “are indicative of continued efforts to eradicate the systemic bias suffered by the girl child in an inherently patriarchal system. Much progress has been made, and yet, much is left to be desired. In sum, while the situation is markedly better than it was in the mid-1990s, the data does not support complacency. The statistics... show that the progress made is incomplete and uneven”.

“Consequently, the integrity and strict enforcement of welfare-oriented legislation such as the PCPNDT Act remain essential along with efforts continued and earnest, till the time there is a widespread change in mentality and what till now is perceived as the ‘inherent weakness’ of the woman is replaced by true equality, when there will dawn a realisation that efforts such as these are no longer required. This is not to say that the laws protecting women within legislation such as IPC/BNS will no longer be required but at least, there will no longer be a question on whether a girl child deserves to

be born,” the court said.

Justice Karol, writing for the bench, referred to noted poet Subhadra Kumari Chauhan’s poem ‘Balika ka Parichay’, which he said “powerfully describes the beautiful joy of a mother upon the birth of her daughter”. The bench added that “to our mind the objective of the...Act...is to enable a woman to feel the same ‘joy’”.

The judgment also quoted the famous shloka ‘Yatra naryastu pujiyante ramante tatra devata’, from Manusmriti, saying “from our own scriptures, the once much cherished but now largely forgotten value is also worth reminding ourselves of”.

The court noted that “according to official Government of India data, the country’s sex ratio has shown clear signs of improvement in recent years, though the story is not entirely straightforward”.

It said, “Census data shows that the national child sex ratio declined from 945 in 1991 to 927 in 2001 and further to 919 in 2011, reflecting the severity of the imbalance that prompted stringent implementation of the PCPNDT Act. The recovery to 929 at birth signals a partial course correction, but yet, not a path of true equality and acceptability. Differences across states drive home this point. For example, Haryana and Punjab, which recorded child sex ratios below 900 in the years immediately after the turn of the century have demonstrated improvement in subsequent surveys showing the success of the regulations as enforced and the awareness measures being implemented. Nonetheless, several states still do report sex ratios at birth below the national average. This shows the continuing presence of deep-seated patriarchal preferences towards a male child and the ‘behind the curtains’ prevalence of sex selection practices”.



R&D underspending in India has no one cause. It's systemic as well as cultural

WHEN ANALYSTS encounter the observation that Indian businesses chronically underinvest in research and development, the instinct is to reach for systemic explanations and to resist cultural ones. The resistance is not unreasonable. Cultural explanations, carelessly deployed, slide into stereotypes, and stereotypes foreclose rather than illuminate. Yet the categorical rejection of culture as an explanatory variable creates its own blind spot, because some of the most persuasive systemic explanations turn out, on inspection, to incorporate cultural elements — not as fixed ethnic traits but as historically conditioned orientations that may change as the circumstances that produced them change.

The truth, as usual, lies in the interaction between multiple causes, none of which is individually sufficient.

The captive market and its seductions

Begin with the most structurally respectable explanation: India's domestic market is vast, and vastness, paradoxically, can be an impediment. A large captive market insulates producers from the bracing pressure of export competition, which has historically been the driving force behind quality improvement and technological upgrading. This is the R&D equivalent of Dutch disease — the same abundance that appears to be an asset quietly erodes the competitive muscle that exposure to harder markets would build. Companies that can grow for decades by serving a billion-plus consumers without venturing beyond the Subcontinent have little incentive to invest in the costly, uncertain process of frontier innovation. Why develop a better product when the existing one sells readily?

The long shadow of colonial deindustrialisation

A second explanation reaches further back. Indian commercial communities have historically been trading rather than manufacturing communities, and while this characterisation admits exceptions, it reflects a genuine historical reality. Whatever manufacturing instincts and capabilities existed before colonial rule were, in many cases, systematically suppressed. The de-industrialisation documented by economic historians — the destruction of India's textile industry, among others — was not merely an economic event; it reshaped the orientation of Indian enterprise toward commerce, intermediation, and arbitrage rather than production and innovation. The few families that retained or rebuilt a manufacturing identity stand as evidence of what might have been more widespread had history taken a different course.

Financialisation before its time

The third explanation may be the most consequential, and is the one with the richest empirical corroboration from other markets. India's corporate sector underwent a degree of financialisation — a shift in priorities from productive investment to financial return — somewhat earlier than its level of industrial development warranted. This sequencing mattered enormously.

The empirical record from developed markets is sobering. William Lazonick's research, published in the Harvard Business Review in 2014, documented how the shareholder-value doctrine drove American corporations to ward stock buybacks and dividends at the expense of investment in capabilities. Between 2003 and 2012, the 449 com-



V ANANTHA NAGESWARAN

India's corporate sector underwent a degree of financialisation — a shift in priorities from productive investment to financial return — somewhat earlier than its level of industrial development warranted

panies that had been continuously listed in the S&P 500 spent 54 per cent of their earnings on buybacks and another 37 per cent on dividends, leaving precious little for R&D. The central argument was that "maximise shareholder value" had been operationalised as "maximise short-term stock price", with predictable consequences for long-run competitiveness. The distortions introduced by executive stock option schemes compound this problem. Research by John Core, Wayne Guay, and David Larcker on equity-based compensation has shown that options tied to short-term stock performance create incentives to manage earnings rather than invest in projects with distant payoffs. R&D expenditure, by its nature, suppresses near-term profits while creating competitive advantage over a horizon of five to 10 years — a horizon that typically outlasts both the executive's tenure and the vesting period of their compensation package. The gains accrue to the executive's successors; the costs fall on the executive's own balance sheet. John Asker, Joan Farre-Mensa, and Alexander Ljungqvist, in a widely cited 2015 study comparing investment behaviour between publicly listed and privately held firms in the US, found that public companies invest substantially less — and are significantly more sensitive to short-

term stock price movements — than comparable private firms facing no such scrutiny. The mechanism was precisely the quarterly reporting cycle.

India's corporate sector absorbed the structural features of financialised capitalism before it had fully developed the manufacturing depth and technological capabilities that American and European corporations pos-

sessed when they eventually succumbed to the same pressures. Germany, Japan, and South Korea financialised their economies only after generating decades of compounding returns on investment in real productive capability. India attempted the transition earlier, with less accumulated capability to draw upon, and is now paying a portion of the price in an R&D intensity that remains well below what its strategic ambitions require.

Democracy, uncertainty, and the discount rate

Competitive popular democracy in a large developing economy generates its own structural uncertainty about the long-term future. Reconciling the demands of a vast and diverse electorate, multiple levels of government, a hostile neighbourhood, and stakeholders with sharply competing interests makes confident long-run prediction genuinely difficult — not as an intellectual failure, but as a rational response to the environment. Businesses internalise this uncertainty directly: The greater the uncertainty about the conditions under which a long-horizon investment must eventually pay off, the higher the discount rate applied to it. R&D expenditure — which suppresses near-term profitability in exchange for competitive returns that may take a decade to materialise — is precisely the kind of commitment that suffers most when discount rates are high. The result is not irrationality; it is the correct pricing of genuine uncertainty. That it produces underinvestment in the capabilities India most needs is the tragedy of the situation, not its justification.

The writer is chief economic advisor, Government of India. This is the first article in a two-part series. The second article will appear tomorrow

From Qatar to US: Changing standards of sports justice



MIHIR VASAVDA

FOUR YEARS ago, much of the Western football world discovered its conscience. Ahead of the 2022 World Cup in Qatar, federations from Norway, Denmark and Germany — and many more — questioned the host's human rights record. The tournament became a referendum on Qatar itself.

Fast forward to 2026, and the contrast is hard to ignore.

Days before the kick-off, Somali referee Omar Artan — selected by FIFA and due to become the first from his country to officiate at a men's World Cup — was denied entry into the US despite holding a valid visa.

FIFA confirmed that he would miss the tournament because all referees are required to operate from the World Cup's central training base in the US.

Artan is one of Africa's most respected referees and was named the continent's best male referee last year. Yet, his World Cup dream ended at an immigration desk.

Former tennis great Martina Navratilova was among the few prominent sporting voices to question the episode. But compared to the moral outrage directed at Qatar before 2022, the silence has been deafening.

The Artan affair is not an isolated incident. Iran, one of the qualified teams, has spent the build-up navigating a maze of restrictions. FIFA regulations guarantee each federation a share of tickets for distribution among supporters, yet Iran says that allocation has effectively been withdrawn.

Journalists, officials and ticket-holding fans from other countries, too, have complained about visa troubles. Last weekend, Iraq striker Aymen Hussein was questioned for nearly seven hours, and his phone was checked when the team arrived in Chicago. The team's photographer was held for more than 10 hours and was denied entry.

This comes against the backdrop of broader American travel restrictions that affect citizens from several nations. Security concerns and the Ebola

outbreak are cited as other reasons for the strictness.

In 2019, when India denied visas to Pakistani shooters ahead of the shooting World Cup in New Delhi following the Pulwama terror attack, the reaction from the Olympic body was swift and severe. It suspended discussions on future events in India and advised international federations against awarding Olympic qualification competitions to the country until guarantees were provided.

The message was clear: Host nations cannot selectively exclude eligible participants.

That principle appears considerably harder to enforce when the host is the world's most powerful country. FIFA's commercial future is tied to the North American market. Broadcasters, sponsors and governing bodies understand where influence resides.

Much of the criticism of Qatar was justified. The US, too, should be held to a difficult standard. Every host nation faces legitimate security concerns and immigration challenges. But consistency matters.

In two years, Los Angeles will host the 2028 Olympics, likely during the final months of Donald Trump's presidency. The International Olympic Committee's charter promises universality. Ensuring that promise may become one of the biggest administrative challenges of the Games.

Earlier World Cups have shown that great goals, underdog stories and unforgettable matches have a way of pushing politics into the background. That may happen again.

But long after the final is played, the memory of this World Cup may not simply be about football. It may also be remembered for exposing a truth about global sport: That principles are often applied unevenly, outrage is frequently selective, and morality sometimes depends on who holds the power.

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The trees that escaped Berger's Ways of Seeing



SUMANA ROY

IT HAS been half a century since an English writer made a series of four films, and then made a book from them. We know that it revolutionised ways of looking at art, and also at humans. *Ways of Seeing* was published two years before I was born — I would first read it only 25 years later. It did not seem to matter to anyone, in those remaining years of the last millennium, that this was a book by a European man, using examples only from European art, focussed only on humans. It didn't occur to anyone to ask: How many trees are there in *Ways of Seeing*? The answer is none, of course — what does that say about our ways of seeing? John Berger would have been 100 years old this year; his ways of seeing — that Matthew Hall has, in a different context, diagnosed as "plant blindness", the socio-optical conditioning of the human species to not notice plant life around them — are not his alone; most of us suffer from this condition.

As someone who suffers from an obverse condition — of noticing plants, in a way that others have called obsessive — what does it mean to find oneself on the other side of the Berger world? I mean, of course, the obvious opposites — a woman, a non-European, from the Indian Subcontinent, raised by a different light, climate, art — but also the less obvious things. Berger was raised by a world where words like "climate" and "ecology" belonged to government brochures. He uses "ecology" in his book once: "Prior to the recent interest in ecology, nature was not thought of as the object of the activities of capitalism.... Aspects of nature were objects of scientific study, but nature as a whole defied possession".

"All images are man-made," Berger asserts. He never uses the word "tree" — his quotes include "apple", "garden", "wheat", "cornstalk"; in two images we see trees in the background, providing shade to the women on whom he — and the artist — focusses his attention. I have no intention of being a correctionist, of playing a game where we scold Aristotle for not being a feminist or Hegel for not thinking of non-European societies. Yet, I feel an unease with the lack of attention to plant life and how it is evidence of the unequal distribution of attention to all living forms, as a result of which we find ourselves here today. Our ways of being have been compelled to accommodate other ways of seeing because of the world we find ourselves in — sweaty, unpredictable, one we can no longer trust as host, slightly hostile, unresponsive to our telepathy, biologically atavistic, with the chance of the return of organisms from an unrecognisable and unknown time.

Why must Berger's ways of seeing give way to what I have, in my head, been calling *ways of treeing*? If *Ways of Seeing* was revolutionary in the way it saw humans in art, what could it imply for us to reverse our focus — where, after centuries of turning all other living forms into background, we notice moss and mycelium, fir and fern, not as compass needle but as the mercury in a thermometer? For not everyone might have been raised by art, but there is possibly no human who hasn't seen a tree.

Tell them then — is there a tree in the *Mona Lisa*?

Roy, a poet and writer, is associate professor, Ashoka University. Views are personal

Los Angeles will host the 2028 Olympics, likely during the final months of Trump's presidency. The IOC's charter promises universality. Ensuring that promise may be one of the Games' biggest administrative challenges

If 'Ways of Seeing' was revolutionary in the way it saw humans in art, what could it imply for us to reverse our focus — where we notice moss and mycelium, fir and fern, not as compass needle but as the mercury in a thermometer?

The Ideas Page

FRIDAY, JUNE 12, 2026

Dowry deaths are about patriarchy and much more



DIPANKAR GUPTA

I HAVE just read the interesting article, “Patriarchy and the mother-in-law trope in India” by Audrey Dmello (IE, June 7). She is right on most counts but elides over a crucial detail. I don’t mean to dispute her assessment, but a few additional issues need to be factored in.

One wonders why a once-oppressed new bride can oppress another just a generation later. Of course, patriarchy has a big role to play, but it is the specific type of patriarchy that matters.

There is patriarchy across the world, but that fact does not lock in with dowry deaths or even dowry. More importantly, there is patriarchy both in north and south India, but dowry deaths occur predominantly in the northern and central states, with the south and even Maharashtra figuring way down in this grisly table.

So it must be patriarchy-plus that accounts for the bulging statistic of dowry deaths in the north. Uttar Pradesh records over 2,000 such deaths annually, while the figure is barely in double digits in Kerala. In terms of cases convicted, Maharashtra, too, has a low incidence of dowry deaths with a conviction rate as low as Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh.

Now, all these states have patriarchy in full flow, so why this difference? The missing link is the way marriage relations are conducted in these regions. In the north, the bride-giver’s family is considered to be of lower social status than that of the bride-taker (recall the *anuloma* and *pratiloma* distinctions). The bride in this case is the beginning of gift-giving between these two families. The woman is the first gift, a supreme gift.

The rationale for dowry begins here. From this initial gift of the virgin (or *kanyadaan*) by the males of the bride’s family begins the continued demand for prestations by the groom’s family. This is not unusual and it solidifies, with multiple iterations, the asymmetrical relationship between bride-giver and bride-taker. The latter believe it is their ritually sanctioned right to demand gifts from the bride’s side in perpetuity. Consequently, the bride is vulnerable in her wedded home and must bend as a subject member of the household.

Contrast this with the southern practice of marriage alliance. Here there is a prevalence of cross-cousin marriage, that is, with the mother’s brother’s daughter. If this rule is strictly followed, then women are returned a generation later to the same extended family that gave a woman earlier. The Gonds of Madhya Pradesh, who also follow this rule of cross-cousin marriage, fetchingly call it “*dudh lautana*”, or return of the milk.

In this scenario, the bride is not a stranger in the groom’s home nor is she a

supreme gift. She is, after all, a cousin! This immediately takes the sting out, in contrast with the unequal relations between bride-giver and bride-taker in the north.

In north India, the bride is constantly reminded of her subjugated status in her married home and this burden is willingly accepted by her side. This explains why her parents are reluctant to take her back even when they learn she is being harassed. If she should, unluckily, give birth to girls, she faces endless acrimony, for now her married family will accuse her of being responsible for pushing them down to accept a lower status when these girls have to be married. She has now debased the whole family.

Contrarily, if a boy is born, this woman becomes a bride taker and joins her husband’s patriarchal family as a near-equal member. In many ways, the mother of the boy transforms into a sociological male. This establishes her position in her husband’s household, which age alone cannot accomplish. As a newly morphed bride-taker, she has all the symbolic energy of the men in her husband’s family.

This unequal relationship has tragic consequences on the flip side when it comes to farmers’ suicides. In those states where dowry deaths are high, farmers’ suicides are low. Hence, counterintuitively, the poor regions of Bihar and Uttar Pradesh (UP), notorious for high dowry deaths, have low rates of farmers’ suicides. Once again, the explanation lies in the difference in marriage customs. This has little to do with poverty, as is often believed.

In the north and south, when an agricultural family is in debt, it is almost always the male in the household who must bear the responsibility. Very often, other family members have little information about their debt status. The male farmer starts by taking a loan. When he cannot repay it, he goes to informal sources, each more rapacious than the next. Finally, when he exhausts these, he turns to his wife’s family for help because his own paternal



kinsfolk are as sunk as he is.

In the north, where dowry is common practice, there is no loss of face in a man asking his in-laws for financial help. This is just another kind of dowry giving and involves no shame. In the south, it is different. The farmer is now borrowing from his wife’s family, with whom his relationship is not that of a superior. In the fullness of time, a girl from his family will be returned to his wife’s family. Therefore, when this financially stressed farmer cannot repay the money he had borrowed from his wife’s father or brother, he is shamed at home and in every family gathering. It is this mounting pressure that finally forces him to die by suicide.

Marriage and kinship explain a lot about both kinds of tragedies. One carries the tragic stain of dowry that leads young brides to death and the other the social shame that compels many male farmer to die by suicide. Patriarchy is a background factor but not the determining variable.

The writer is a sociologist



OPHELIA YUMLEMBAM

India-Myanmar ties will remain limited

greater diplomatic manoeuvrability. Second, the military’s control remains weakest in western and southwestern Myanmar along the Indian border, especially Rakhine State. This region is of importance to India as it hosts key Act East Policy (AEP) investments. Finally, economic considerations may have been a major driver of the visit. Myanmar’s economy remains far below its pre-coup trajectory, with high inflation, weak growth, and nearly half of the population living in poverty.

India has good reason for deepening its engagement. The rise in refugee flows, cross-border insurgent activity, illicit trafficking networks and other non-traditional security threats has heightened concerns. The prolonged delays in key connectivity projects under the AEP have added to the urgency. While demonstrating a willingness to engage with the new administration in Myanmar, India also

underscored that its core national interests remain non-negotiable.

China is another important factor. For Myanmar, closer engagement with India offers an opportunity to reduce excessive dependence on China. For New Delhi, deeper engagement with Naypyidaw serves as a means of balancing Chinese influence in India’s immediate neighbourhood. But achieving either objective will be challenging. Over the past five years, while many countries limited their engagement with Myanmar’s junta, China continued to provide political, economic, and military support. Naypyidaw is unlikely to move away from its long-standing “Pauk-Phaw” relationship with Beijing. Unless alternative partners can offer comparable levels of support, investment, and security cooperation, China will remain Myanmar’s most consequential external partner. Given the circumstances, India is

neither willing nor positioned to match China’s level of engagement.

The absence of major agreements, substantial new commitments, or significant MoUs during Min Aung Hlaing’s trip underscores that while India is prepared to engage, it remains reluctant to significantly expand cooperation as long as Myanmar’s internal conflict and political uncertainties persist. Ultimately, the long-term trajectory of the relationship will depend largely on how the new administration in Myanmar manages its own political and security challenges and proves its commitment to addressing India’s security concerns. Until its political and security landscape becomes more stable, India-Myanmar ties are likely to remain pragmatic, cautious, and limited in scope.

The writer is a research associate at the Organisation for Research on China and Asia



● PERSONAL FINANCE

How NRIs can make equity-like returns — from bank deposits

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, June 11

THE RESERVE Bank of India's (RBI) Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) deposit swap scheme, which aims to boost foreign inflows, is an alluring investment opportunity for non-resident Indians (NRIs). On Wednesday, banks began raising interest rates on these deposits. HDFC Bank increased rates to 6% on three to five-year deposits. YES Bank is offering 6.5-6.6%. This 6-6.6% return is only the tip of the iceberg — thanks to leverage.

How leverage works in finance

Leverage means borrowing money to amplify the return from an investment. The leverage is 2x if a person borrows two times the money they have, or their capital; it is 10x if ten times the capital is borrowed. This leverage can help NRIs make huge returns from FCNR(B) deposits. Say an NRI in the US wants to deposit \$1 million in an FCNR(B) deposit for three years. While depositing this money will get an annual return of 6%, the NRI can borrow \$10 million from a US bank — for three years — at their lower interest rates and put this money in the FCNR(B) deposit. A three-year loan in the US costs around 4.5%. So, the interest from the FCNR(B) deposit of \$11 million in Year 1 is \$660,000, while the cost of the borrowed \$10 million is \$450,000. This means a net gain of \$210,000. After three years, the \$11 million deposit at 6% will be worth \$13.1 million. Repayment on the \$10 million loan at 4.5% will be \$11.4 million, resulting in a gain of \$1.7 million on a capital of \$1 million — or a compounded annual rate of interest of 19.3% (*see table*).

Equity-like returns

Two crucial factors determine how high this final rate of return can be. The first is the difference between the rate of interest on the FCNR(B) deposit and the rate at which NRIs can borrow abroad to leverage their capital. The greater the difference (or spread, in financial parlance), the greater is the return. The second is the leverage. The higher the leverage, the higher the return. Emkay Global Financial Services says: "Returns from the scheme approach equity-like returns as leverage is increased". As investors take advantage of the ability to take leverage, "flows under the scheme could be at least \$50-\$55 billion (around 1.2% of GDP) and possibly even higher". In 2013, when the swap scheme was first announced as a temporary measure to boost foreign inflows, NRIs used leverage to pour in \$26 billion — around 1.4% of India's GDP at the time — into FCNR(B) deposits.

Allowing leverage

But how is the NRI able to use leverage in the first place? Because of something called a letter of credit. Normally, Indian banks can't issue guarantees or letters of credit that assure repayment of money that has been borrowed. However, the RBI has decided this rule does not apply for the purpose of this FCNR(B) swap scheme. As such, an NRI can get a letter of credit from the Indian bank with which they are making the FCNR(B) deposit and use it to borrow from the American bank, who is now assured of being paid back by the NRI once the FCNR(B) deposit matures. The NRI wins, the American bank wins, the Indian bank wins, and the Indian economy wins.

● How much an NRI can make

	LEVERAGE	
	5X	10X
NRI's capital	\$1 m	\$1 m
NRI borrows	\$5 m	\$10 m
Cost of borrowing (interest rate)	4.5%	4.5%
FCNR(B) deposit amount	\$6 m	\$11 m
FCNR(B) deposit interest rate	6%	6%
Repayment sum on 3-year US loan	\$5.7 m	\$11.4 m
FCNR(B) deposit after 3 years	\$7.1 m	\$13.1 m
NRI's return	\$1.4 m	\$1.7 m
Compounded annual rate of interest	11.9%	19.3%

RATES, LEVERAGE ARE HYPOTHETICAL SCENARIOS; INDIAN EXPRESS CALCULATIONS

● AVIATION

Amid uncertainty over AI 171 report, a look at the key theories behind the crash

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, June 11

FRIDAY MARKS the first anniversary of the Air India flight AI 171 crash that killed 260 people. The one-year mark is also when air crash investigators are typically expected to reveal some of their findings. All eyes, therefore, are on India's Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB). There are two primary theories about the likely causes of the Boeing 787-8 Dreamliner crash. The first is pilot action, widely reported in Western media. The second is a catastrophic electrical or systems failure, a theory that has found support among India's pilot community, a section of aviation safety experts and even a few Boeing whistleblowers. The trigger for the crash, as identified in the AAIB's preliminary report released after a month of the accident, was the transitioning of both engine fuel control

switches from 'RUN' to 'CUTOFF' position almost immediately after liftoff from Ahmedabad. The critical question is this: How did the switches, which control the flow of fuel to the engines, transition? Over the past year, the AAIB and other wings of the Ministry of Civil Aviation have been tight-lipped about the investigation, save for the preliminary report and press releases to clarify or deny Western news reports based on leaks in the US or Europe. In the run-up to the crash's first anniversary, too, there is silence on what the AAIB will put out, and in what form. The indications are that the agency may not be able to furnish the full investigation report, and could instead issue an interim report or a status update. According to *Reuters* and *Bloomberg*, the final report is expected to be delayed by a few months as the detailed technical analysis of the ill-fated aircraft's engines is yet to be completed in the US.

AIR INDIA CRASH
a year later

● LEGAL

Why Khurram Parvez got bail despite stringent UAPA conditions

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, June 11

FOUR-AND-A-HALF YEARS after his arrest in a terror-conspiracy case investigated by the National Investigation Agency (NIA), Kashmiri rights activist Khurram Parvez was granted bail by the Delhi High Court on Wednesday. The Division Bench comprising Justices Navin Chawla and Ravinder Dodeja held that the prolonged period that Parvez spent in custody, along with the slow progress of the trial and his disability, had justified his release despite the stringent bail restrictions under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA). "The appellant's right under Article 21 of the Constitution of India need to be balanced and may even trump the restriction imposed under Section 43D(5) of the UAPA," the court said. The bail order pertains to the case in which Parvez was arrested in November 2021. Parvez, however, will continue to remain in jail on account of another NIA case of 2020, in which he was formally arrested

in 2023 while already in custody. The bail application in that case remains pending before the trial court. *The case against Parvez* The NIA case originated from an FIR registered in November 2021, alleging that the banned terror outfit Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) had established a network of operatives and over-ground workers across India through a handler. While Parvez was not named in the FIR, he was arrested during the investigation. According to the NIA, Parvez was a part of a larger conspiracy involving LeT operatives and supporters. He was alleged to have collected information related to army movements near the Line of Control, which Parvez disputed, stating that the information "primarily revolves around fact-finding, research, and documentation of atrocities faced by civilians due to state excess and/or militancy."

What the High Court held

The court held that the period of imprisonment without progress in trial had to

Bail yardstick

● The court held that the period of imprisonment without progress in trial had to be taken into consideration. ● The appellant's right under Article 21 need to be balanced and may even trump the restriction under Section 43D(5) of the UAPA,' it said.

be taken into consideration. Parvez had spent almost four and a half years in custody, and the proceedings were still at the stage of arguments. The court observed that "the long period of incarceration of the appellant and the fact that there is no likelihood of the trial ending soon as also against the yardstick of bail being the rule, while denial thereof being an exception. The appellant's rights under Article 21 of the Constitution of India need to be balanced and may even trump the restriction imposed under Section 43D(5) of the UAPA." The court noted that the prosecution case against Parvez rested substantially on the statement of the co-accused Muneer Ahmad Kataria, who had turned approver in 2019 and whose evidence remained to be tested during trial.

Legal framework

The case turns on Section 43D(5) of the UAPA, which states that courts should not grant bail if, upon examining the case diary or chargesheet, they find reasonable grounds to believe that the "accusations

against such person is prima facie true". In practice, this creates a significantly higher threshold for bail than in ordinary criminal cases. Over the last few years, however, courts have increasingly been confronted with whether an accused should be kept in prison indefinitely while waiting for trial. In *Union of India v. K.A. Najeer* (2021), the Supreme Court held that constitutional courts retain the power to grant bail where prolonged incarceration and delay in trial threaten fundamental rights under Article 21. It noted: "At the commencement of proceedings, the courts are expected to appreciate the legislative policy against grant of bail, however, these restrictions will melt down where there is no likelihood of the trial being completed within a reasonable time and the period of incarceration already undergone has exceeded a substantial part of the prescribed sentence." At the same time, recent SC decisions in the cases of Gulfisha Fatima and Syed Ifikhar Andrabi, along with a recent reference to a larger bench of the top court, show that the law remains in flux.



The tail of the Boeing 787-8 Dreamliner in June last year. SANKHADEEP BANERJEE/FILE

The two theories

The preliminary findings narrowed the focus to the transitioning of the fuel control switches from 'RUN' to 'CUTOFF' within a second of each other, moments after the plane became airborne.

The preliminary report said that in the cockpit voice recording, one of the pilots was heard asking the other why he cut off the fuel, to which the other pilot responded saying he did not. There has been speculation on whether the switches were flipped by one of the pilots — inadvertently or otherwise — or whether the transition signal to the system was due to a technical, mechanical or software issue. The AAIB report did not state that either pilot physically flipped the switches. The selective exchange in the preliminary report led many to believe that it pointed a finger at the flight crew, particularly the flight's captain Sumeet Sabharwal, a highly experienced pilot. Some Western news outlets reported that the probe was zeroing in on deliberate action by one of the pilots. Pilot bodies objected to the preliminary report and the insinuations that followed, as did some aviation experts. The AAIB, too, has pushed back against the narrative that the preliminary report

had sufficiently established deliberate pilot action as the cause of the crash. Some safety experts have suggested that the aircraft may have suffered a major electrical failure as it took off, which could have cut fuel supply to the engines. The flight data recorder would have recorded it as the fuel control switches moving to the 'CUTOFF' position even if they didn't actually move. Moreover, a US-based aviation safety advocacy group claimed in January that the crashed aircraft had experienced a number of engineering, manufacturing, quality, and maintenance problems in its service life of 11 years, leading to electrical systems failures. In a whistleblower report to the US Senate Permanent Subcommittee on Investigations, the Foundation for Aviation Safety alleged that critical safety concerns pertaining to the Boeing 787 aircraft fleet persist. The group suggested that "latent defects" could be a cause of the accident and remain a concern.

PM SURYA GHAR SEES 40 LAKH INSTALLATIONS SO FAR

Local cell mandate may hit solar scheme

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, June 11

THE CENTRE’s plan to install rooftop solar panels in 75 lakh households by year-end may hit a few bumps due to the limited availability and rising costs of these panels made from domestically-manufactured solar cells.

About 40 lakh rooftop systems have been installed under the PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana so far, adding over 12 gigawatts (GW) capacity. Vendors and installers empanelled under the scheme across multiple states told *The Indian Express* that they are struggling to procure Domestic Content Requirement (DCR)-compliant solar panels, which are mandatory under the scheme.

Some claimed that the waiting period was 25–30 days.

DCR-compliant solar panels are those in which locally manufactured solar cells — components that convert sunlight into electricity — are used. Taking cognizance of the issue, Santosh Kumar Sarangi, Secretary at Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) on Monday held a meeting with domestic solar cell manufacturers to emphasise the need to ensure adequate availability of domestically-manufactured solar PV cells and DCR solar modules, especially for vendors and installers engaged in setting up of Distributed Renewable Energy (DRE) solar projects like solar rooftop plants and solar agricultural pumps, while also keeping the prices reasonable.

“Ministry of New & Renewable Energy (MNRE), through REC Limited and National Institute of Solar Energy (NISE), is keeping a close eye on the availability and prices of domestically manufactured solar cells and modules and is closely monitoring the situation,” the ministry said in response to queries sent by *The Indian Express*. “With domestic solar PV cell manufacturing capacity expected to rise substantially in the next few months, the demand supply situation is expected to improve further,” it added.

New mandate triggers price rise

According to the ministry, prices of DCR solar PV modules — domestically manufactured modules made using domestically produced solar PV cells —



Centre has made it mandatory for all projects to use only locally manufactured solar cells in the solar panels. REUTERS

have risen in May.

The ministry attributed this price increase in May to a likely surge in demand from developers seeking to commission net-metering and open-access renewable energy projects before the May 31, 2026 deadline, after which the exemption from mandatory domestic cell sourcing requirements expired.

From June 1, the government made it mandatory for all domestic, commercial and industrial solar projects to use only locally manufactured solar cells in the solar panels deployed in those projects.

While the move is aimed at reducing India’s dependence on imports and strengthening the domestic solar manufacturing ecosystem, industry stakeholders say it has also exposed a critical supply gap.

India currently lacks sufficient domestic cell manufacturing capacity to meet the rapidly growing demand for solar installations.

In 2025-26, India added around 45 GW of solar capacity. Against an annual solar module production of around 60-65 GW, India’s solar cell manufacturing capacity stands at only about 30 GW. As a result, a significant portion of the country’s module production has historically relied on imported cells.

Even though the Domestic Content Requirement (DCR) has long been mandatory for rooftop solar installations under the PM Surya Ghar scheme, the recent extension of domestic cell sourcing norms to additional segments, including commercial and industrial projects, has significantly increased demand for solar modules manufactured using locally produced cells.

Industry stakeholders say the sudden surge in demand

has outpaced available domestic manufacturing capacity, creating a supply-demand mismatch. This has led to shortages of DCR-compliant modules and a sharp rise in prices, potentially slowing the rollout of rooftop solar systems and other distributed renewable energy projects across the country.

‘Project execution slowdown’

Several vendors who install solar systems under the PM Surya Ghar scheme told *The Indian Express* that they are grappling with a severe shortage of DCR-compliant solar modules. They said that even when modules are available, prices have risen sharply.

Vendors from Uttar Pradesh, Haryana and Odisha reported waiting periods of 25–30 days for DCR-compliant panels, with many approaching the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) seeking intervention.

“The industry is currently facing a severe shortage of DCR-certified solar modules. Leading manufacturers such as Adani, Waaree, Premier Energies and other major suppliers are operating at full capacity and have long waiting periods for deliveries,” said Vijay Kumar, President of the Solar Ardent Association in Haryana and Managing Director of Indivm Energy Private Limited. According to Vijay, the supply crunch has left many rooftop solar installers across the country struggling to procure modules in the required quantities, leading to delays in project execution and uncertainty for consumers who have already received approvals or made advance payments.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

TCS ties up with Anthropic to help clients on enterprise AI adoption

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, June 11

Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), India’s largest IT services company, on Thursday announced a global strategic partnership with Anthropic, the frontier AI company behind Claude, to help customers scale enterprise AI adoption.

TCS will setup a dedicated Business Unit focused on delivering strong customer value propositions, joint industry solutions and deep AI expertise on the Claude family of models through early access to Claude models, TCS said.

“In regulated industries, most AI initiatives stall at the pilot stage, where the requirements for accuracy, auditability and oversight are far more stringent, and the consequences of error significantly

higher. This partnership is designed to overcome those barriers,” it said in a statement.

Combining TCS’ governance, controls and implementation expertise will enable enterprises to deploy Claude confidently in production, not just in experimentation, TCS said. Dario Amodei, Co-founder and CEO, Anthropic, said, “We built Claude to be safe, trusted, and helpful, particularly in contexts where accuracy matters most. This partnership deepens our commitment to India, our second-largest market, with TCS bringing Claude to enterprises and professionals across the region and globally, including 50,000 of its employees.”

As a global premier partner in the Claude Partner Network, TCS will bring Claude models to enterprises that demand accuracy, deep integration, resil-

ience and strong governance, the Indian tech firm said.

Combining scaled internal deployment, joint go-to-market offerings, industry co-innovation, and workforce enablement, the partnership gives clients a practical path to enterprise-wide adoption and measurable outcomes, it said.

TCS said it will equip 50,000 associates across engineering, finance, legal, marketing, and sales with Claude through enterprise-wide licensing. By deploying Claude internally, TCS will gain first-hand experience to transform its own operations while applying those insights to drive client success, TCS said.

TCS and Anthropic will jointly go to market with AI solutions and services across industries including highly regulated sectors. **FULL REPORT ON**
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

LOWERS ITS GLOBAL GROWTH OUTLOOK FOR 2026 TO 2.5% AMID ESCALATING CONFLICT IN WEST ASIA

World Bank raises India’s FY27 growth forecast to 6.6%

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, June 11

THE WORLD Bank marginally raised its growth outlook for India to 6.6% from 6.5% for the financial year 2027 (FY27), even as it cut its global growth forecast for 2026 to 2.5% due to the war in the West Asia.

In its June 2026 Global Economic Prospects report, the World Bank raised India’s growth estimate for FY28 by 0.6 percentage point to 7.2%.

“Despite heightened uncertainty related to the conflict, economic activity in India remained robust early this year, supported by resilient domestic demand,” the World Bank said, adding that private consumption, particularly in rural areas, has been strong, with urban demand recovering. Collections of taxes from domestic sales have also in-

creased steadily. To mitigate price pressures arising from higher energy costs, as well as shortages of agricultural products, especially fertilizers, several measures have been implemented in India, including a reduction in fuel taxes.

However, it said the moderation in growth from 7.7% in FY26 to an estimated 6.6% in FY27 reflects a slowdown in private demand growth owing to higher energy prices and other input costs, although a reduction in Goods and Services Tax rates should provide some support to consumer demand.

“Reduced US tariffs and the expected implementation of free trade agreements will likely mitigate the impact of weaker external demand due to the conflict, particularly on merchandise exports. Growth is then anticipated to rebound



In several economies, including India, fiscal deficits are anticipated to rise, the Bank said. FILE

over the next two financial years, driven by firming domestic demand and a pickup in export growth,” it said.

In several economies, including India, fiscal deficits are anticipated to rise, partly owing to increases in subsidies

intended to counter surges in energy prices, it said.

In India, reduced revenues due to tax reforms are forecast to be partly offset by slower capital expenditure growth and reductions in non-essential current spending, it added.

“Over the forecast horizon, trade agreements and structural reforms undertaken to improve the business environment are set to support foreign direct investment inflows in India,” the World Bank said.

The Bank cut its global growth forecast for 2026 to 2.5% due to the war in the Middle East and said growth could slow to just 1.3% if energy supply disruptions prove more severe and are accompanied by substantial stress in financial markets.

Global growth reached 2.9% in 2025, the Bank said in its semi-annual Global Economic Prospects report, up 0.2 percentage point from its estimate in January. Its 2026 forecast is down 0.1 percentage point from January and would mark the weakest growth rate since the COVID-19 pandemic began in late 2019. FE

FM: Strengthen multilateral cooperation to tackle challenges

New Delhi: Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Thursday said the adverse impact of conflicts and uncertainty falls disproportionately on developing countries and the Global South, and there is a need for coordinated global action to deal with it.

Addressing the ‘Global Convergence for Growth Summit’, the finance minister said there is a need to strengthen multilateral cooperation to build resilient economies, accelerate sustainable development, and ensure inclusive growth that benefits everyone. PTI



● HEALTH AUTHORITIES ARE STRUGGLING TO CATCH UP WITH THE MUSHROOMING EPIDEMIC OF A RARE EBOLA STRAIN THAT KILLS 30% TO 50% OF THOSE INFECTED AND HAS NO VACCINE OR CURE

Outbreak: A cracked coffin, a funeral and the hunt for Ebola’s patient zero

Giulia Paravicini, Clement Bonnerot & Fiston Mahamba
June 11

THE BODY of a Congolese Pastor Paluku Makundi Denis, 44, lay inside a wooden coffin strapped into the aging Nissan SUV’s back as it made its way to Mongbwalu. A group of young relatives were sitting atop the casket. By the time they reached, the coffin was cracked.

Investigators are hunting for the "patient zero", or earliest infection, of the Ebola epidemic raging in the war-torn Democratic Republic of Congo, according to four experts on the team conducting the health

ministry inquiry.

Health authorities are struggling to catch up with the mushrooming epidemic of a rare Ebola strain that kills 30% to 50% of those infected and has no vaccine or cure. The outbreak has caused about 635 confirmed infections and at least 127 deaths in eastern Congo, according to the country's health ministry. The true toll could be much higher, officials warn.

A surveillance epidemiologist on the inquiry estimated the strain, Bundibugyo, had been circulating for four to six months before Congo's outbreak was confirmed on May 15. He stressed more work is needed to determine whether Pastor Ma-

kundi, who was never tested for Ebola, was infected and to identify the outbreak's origin — a key step to understanding its scale and preventing further epidemics.

The corpse was transferred into a new casket by residents who touched the remains before community members converged for the funeral – a perilous move if Makundi had Ebola because victims' bodies are highly infectious.

A Bunia hospital had diagnosed Makundi with peritonitis, a severe abdominal infection, on February 3, according to sources.

David Heymann, an infectious-disease professor at the London School of Hygiene and



Red Cross workers wearing personal protective equipment (PPE) work at the house of an unidentified man who died of Ebola. REUTERS

Tropical Medicine, said peritonitis is one manifestation of a severe Ebola infection but it was impossible to confirm without

testing. More than 80 relatives, friends and neighbours assembled at the local cemetery at

dusk, according to Edmond Kambale Katuwene, the leader of the town's Nande community.

In the following days, several relatives and community members began falling ill, Mongbwalu's Mayor Sesereki Mandro Israel said. Nearly 50 deaths were recorded within two weeks of the burial, he said, with many presenting symptoms of Ebola: fever, vomiting, bleeding.

His relatives' deaths preceded at least 108 deaths in Mongbwalu between April and May, according to the Ituri authority report, an arm of the national health ministry. Patients in family clusters collapsed with fever, vomiting, diarrhea and in some cases hemorrhaging

symptoms, it said. The disease, it said, might have smoldered undetected in Mongbwalu for months.

Congo's health ministry said on June 9 that at least 40 people were confirmed to have died of Ebola in Mongbwalu. Aid workers warned the official figures may be incomplete due to limited testing.

The original casket was set on fire. None of the six relatives and locals interviewed said they witnessed the fire, though all reported seeing the coffin's burnt remains. Pastor Makundi's father and uncle blamed a group of intoxicated youths but had no further details. Among residents, the burned coffin was

viewed as an affront to ancestors, community leader Katuwene said.

The unease had deepened after the burial of Tsongo Kenda Kenda, Makundi's younger brother, when local police intervened during a dispute. Katuwene said family members had argued over where the pre-burial wake should be held and that a relative removed the coffin lid in protest before putting it back on. Such meddling is viewed by many as disrespectful to the dead, Katuwene added. Jeremy Rayan Tamelegu, who was working as a mining-geology consultant, said the unexplained surge in sickness and death fed into the curse narrative. REUTERS